Coppo di Marcovaldo, the teacher of Cimabue), probably terrifying in the eyes of a medieval person, has often been indicated as a source of inspiration to Dante (figure 3.15).

Shortly before starting to write this book, I visited the Baptistery in the company of Emanuela Minnai, the friend who convinced me to write it. Entering the Baptistery and looking up, you see a shining point of light (the light source from the lantern at the summit of the cupola) surrounded by nine orders of angels, with the name of each order written: Angels, Archangels, Principalities, Powers, Virtues, Domains, Thrones, Cherubim and Seraphim. This corresponds exactly to the structure of the second sphere of Paradise. Imagine that you are an ant on the floor of the Baptistery and are able to walk in any direction; regardless of which direction you follow to climb the wall, you would reach the ceiling at the same point of light surrounded by angels: the point of light and its angels both ‘surround’ and ‘are surrounded by’ the rest of the decorated interior of the Baptistery (figure 3.16).



Figure 3.15 The mosaic depicting Hell, by Coppo di Marcovaldo, in the Baptistery of Florence.

Like every citizen of Florence at the end of the thirteenth century, Dante must have been profoundly awe-struck by the Baptistery, the grandiose architectural enterprise his city was completing. I believe that he may have been inspired by the Baptistery, not only by Coppo di Marcovaldo’s *Inferno*, but also by its overall architecture, for his vision of the cosmos. The *Paradiso* reproduces its structure remarkably precisely, including the nine circles of angels and the point of light, just translating it from two to three dimensions. After describing the spherical universe of Aristotle, Brunetto had already written that beyond it lies the place of divinity – and medieval iconography had already imagined Paradise as God surrounded by spheres of angels. In the end, Dante does no more than mount the pieces that already existed into a coherent architectural whole which follows the suggestive architecture of the Baptistery and resolves the ancient problem of the borders of the universe. In so doing, Dante anticipates by six centuries Einstein’s 3-sphere.